

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Water purification

FIELD SKILLS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Use safe bottled water when available. For microbial risk, bring clear water to a rolling boil for 1 minute, or 3 minutes above 6,500 feet, and cool before use. Water contaminated with fuel, chemicals or radioactive material cannot be made safe by boiling or ordinary disinfection.

Do now.

- ☐ **Check the source**
01 Avoid floodwater or sources suspected of toxic contamination; find an approved alternative.
- ☐ **Clarify cloudy water**
02 Let sediment settle or strain through a clean cloth before treatment; this alone does not disinfect it.
- ☐ **Boil for germs**
03 Use the appropriate time and cool safely in a clean container.
- ☐ **If boiling is unavailable**
04 Use a treatment product as labeled and official guidance for your water source; filters have different capabilities.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Choose the least contaminated available source and establish whether the problem is microbial or chemical. If the source may contain fuel, industrial chemicals or radioactive material, find another source; a camping filter or boiling is not a universal solution.

Watch for.

Clear water can still contain germs. Ordinary filters may not remove viruses or chemicals.

People & practical needs.

Keep untreated and treated water in different labeled containers. Use clean utensils and teach each person how safe water is dispensed. Plan extra care for infant feeding and people with weakened immunity; a field filter is not automatically suitable for every medical use.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Store treated water in clean covered containers and prevent recontamination.

Check the next usable option

Store treated water in clean covered containers and prevent recontamination.

When the first option is unavailable

Choose the least contaminated available source and establish whether the problem is microbial or chemical. If the source may contain fuel, industrial chemicals or radioactive material, find another source; a camping filter or boiling is not a universal solution.

Questions in the field.

Does clear water mean safe water?

No. Clarity does not show whether germs, fuel, pesticides or other chemicals are present. Select the safest source available and identify suspected contamination before choosing treatment. Boiling or ordinary filtration does not resolve every chemical hazard.

What if the label differs from an online recipe?

Follow the exact treatment product instructions for the water condition, volume and contact time. Do not mix products or estimate a stronger dose. A device's microbial claims and maintenance requirements must match the actual task.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

[Water purification · official guidance](#)

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/index.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/guides/water-purification/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.